

Concept note: the product we are building

Final direction after the 5 September alignment. One page of story, one page of mechanics, one page of positioning. The build brief is a separate document.

The product in one paragraph

Agent Passport is the trust layer for AI agents acting on payment infrastructure. Firms are deploying agents that pay invoices at scale; banks cannot tell whose agent sent an instruction, whether it is inside its authority, or who answers when it is fooled, and since October 2024 banks reimburse the resulting APP fraud themselves (roughly £450M a year in the UK, £11,000 average per business incident). We give the authority a registry and every institution a single verify call: before any payment executes, the bank confirms the agent carries provable, revocable, human-granted authority. People use the web; agents use rails. We are the rail's border control.

The scenario (canonical names)

Northgate Joinery, a small business, pays suppliers through PayRail, a licensed payment provider whose AI agent reads invoices and pays them automatically. Under the proposed KY-A assurance framework, PayRail submits evidence about the agent before deploying it. An AI assistant on the authority's side reads the pile and lays the facts out with page references; written rules check them; a human supervisor signs, adding a condition of her own (any payment above £5,000 needs human confirmation). The agent receives its passport. When it sends a payment, Northgate's bank checks the passport before the money moves, then pays, holds for a human, or refuses, with the reason written down. The authority can suspend or revoke at any time; repeated violations escalate back to it.

The composite passport (the architecture idea)

The passport is not one credential. It is three, stapled together, each signed by the only party entitled to make the claim, so none can alter what the others signed:

Signer	Claim
Payments authority	PayRail is licensed; the agent passed KY-A assurance; supervisor condition attached; revocable in real time via the registry.
PayRail (provider)	This specific agent: its name, public key and software configuration. Every payment instruction is signed with that key, so a copied passport is useless.
Northgate (customer)	The commercial mandate: these suppliers, this cap per payment, this much per month, this expiry. Signed by the finance director.

The bank is the relying party: one registry call, ordered deterministic checks, deny by default, ALLOW / ESCALATE / DENY with a rule citation and a signed receipt. Every decision is hash-chained and replayable. Revocation flips one registry row; the agent's next action fails everywhere. AI sits at the edges only: it reads evidence into quote-anchored facts and drafts notes; rules decide; humans sign.

Why each party wants it

- **Regulator:** sees agents before they act instead of investigating after; every agent resolves to a licensed provider and a named accountable person; supervision scales to machine speed because checks are code and rules ship as data.
- **Banks:** a pre-execution liability shield. They now eat APP fraud losses; one verify call answers whether the payee, amount and volume are inside the customer-signed mandate.
- **Providers:** a market-access credential. A passported agent is one banks will accept.
- **Customers:** automation that cannot exceed what they signed, even when the agent is fooled by a fake invoice.

The money shot

The redirected invoice dying at the bank: a fraud email substitutes supplier bank details, the agent is fooled, the payment is refused (payee not on the customer-signed mandate), the incident is logged to the supervisor. £11,000 saved, on screen, with a rule citation. Everything in the demo builds to and away from this beat.

vouch.finance: the enforcement layer

vouch.finance (non-profit, Finternet / Networks for Humanity, the Aadhaar and UPI lineage) runs a purpose-bound value rail: mandates with money-rules enforced at transaction time. Their own documentation says the current agent identity handle is a stand-in until agent-passport work replaces it. So the division of labour is exact and nothing is decorative: we authorise the agent (who it is, who assured it, who answers); their rail programs the money (caps, counterparties, settlement). Integration: officer approval mints the matching mandate on their rail; revocation kills it there too, so one supervisory action makes two independent rails refuse, on screen; allowed payments can settle through their rail as defence in depth. We also replay their adversarial kits through our engine (over-limit, split-payment structuring, revoked-authority reuse, all caught) and publish a one-page compatibility spec mapping our passport fields onto their mandate: the KY-A extension their roadmap names. Built with vouch.finance: Yes, as architecture.

What we deliberately do not claim

- We do not move money; settlement is whatever rail the bank already uses (vouch in the demo, Faster Payments tomorrow). Rail-agnostic is what makes this infrastructure.
- We do not do the bank's KYC, sanctions screening or funds checks, and we do not judge whether an invoice is wise, only whether the agent had authority.
- This is a proposed assurance framework demonstrated on synthetic data, mirroring how regulators handled payment initiation under Open Banking: the payment stays ordinary, the new intermediary and its risks get assured.
- No invented cryptography and no blockchain in our layer: Ed25519 signatures, JWT, a registry, a hash-chained log. Deployable by an authority tomorrow, which is the point.

Transferability

The vertical is a rule pack. The same engine, with the tax rule pack, already authorises a tax-filing agent end to end (built and deployed). Swap the pack again and it covers government incentive schemes or any sector where third-party agents act on public infrastructure. One protocol, many verticals: shown in one 30-second beat, claimed as infrastructure.

One line for everything

Firms want to automate payments, banks are liable for what agents authorise, and regulators cannot see any of it. Agent Passport lets an agent prove, before the money moves, exactly what it is allowed to do and who answers for it.

Figures: PSR mandatory reimbursement (in force 7 Oct 2024, £85,000 cap, five business days, cost shared between sending and receiving PSP); UK Finance Annual Fraud Report 2025 (APP losses just over £450M in 2024); AccessPay analysis (business losses £83.3M, average business APP transaction £11,000).